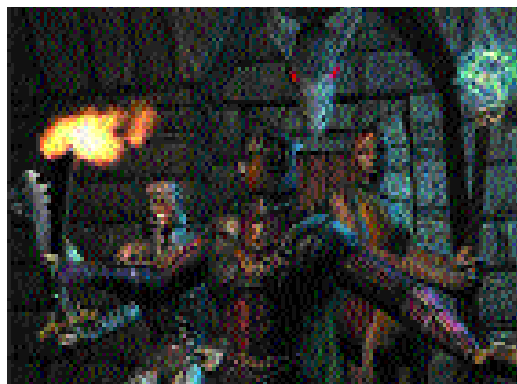


publisher for a while now, but no agreement has been reached and we have run out of cash. This means that there will be no further development on the game," thus wrote Julian Gollop, a Mythos programmer. This time however, the ending need not be a bitter one. For the allure of the *X-Com* license soon saw the project change developer hands and a Czech gaming house, Altar Interactive, took over the task, changing its name to *UFO: Aftermath*. The game shows a healthy pulse and will hopefully soon see the light of day.

Another high-profile project that found itself on a sinking ship was the sequel to the highly acclaimed action/adventure game, *Outcast*. Fans and critics alike were distressed to learn that *Outcast 2* was in development limbo as its creator, Appeal, was forced to file for bankruptcy. Speculation that the game was dead, forced the company to issue an apologetic statement, "Sometimes these kind of things happen. Unfortunately, we cannot disclose much about the situation, but please keep in mind that *Outcast 2* is not cancelled—it has been suspended for an undefined period of time." One hopes that the 'undefined period of time' does not stretch for long, since games have a very short shelf life—what was a fresh concept not too long ago can be as stale as yesterday's news in the blink of an eye.

Of moving platforms and maths

Another malady that forces a game to go off the radars of hopeful fans and critics has been duly studied, recorded and labelled as 'The Strange Case of Jumping Platforms'. Platforms, refer to consoles such as the Sony PlayStation, Microsoft's Xbox, the personal computer even. It so happens that when a game is being planned, certain features become difficult to implement, thanks largely to inherent limitations of the destined platform. If these features form the essence of the game, the developers find it more apt to introduce their game to a more suitable hardware. Case in point, Silicon Knights' *Eternal Darkness*. Originally slated for Nintendo's N64, the developers found that the console was not powerful enough to handle the game



ULTIMATE SHOW: Origin terminated the development of *Ultima Online 2* as they thought that the sequel would dilute the market of their primary cash-cow—*Ultima Online*



HALO GROUND: Widely hailed as the game to carry PC gaming forever, *Halo* jumped ships, got cosy with the Xbox and is not expected to revolutionise console games for some time to come

“ I don't look upon it as failure but as a very long learning experience. It's a failure if you just keep doing the same thing over and over again. But it was an expensive lesson to some extent ”

Bill Roper, Producer, *Warcraft Adventures*, *Blizzard North*

and decided to unveil their creation on the Gamecube. For similar reasons, *Soul Reaver 2* abandoned its PlayStation roots in favour of its more capable sibling, the PlayStation 2.

Now picture yourself in the shoes of a gaming fan who has just ditched the platform... feelings of betrayal and angst course through your veins right about now. Owners of the Dreamcast were

bombarded with such emotions when Sega decided to discontinue its production. Games that were to appear on the Dreamcast switched platforms, leaving a disheartened bunch of gamers in the lurch. Some of the heartbreakers were Valve's *Half-Life* and Crystal Dynamic's *Rever 2*.

A more common reason for a game being ditched stems from its very nature. A game is a difficult beast to tame. The technical expertise required to bring a project to the finish line and the artistic touch needed to fuel its success often do not simultaneously present themselves. Thus a symbiosis of sorts has been established in the gaming pond—the guy who is good at maths makes a great engine, sell it to the literary types, who then attach a beautiful aerodynamic chassis and a great story rolls out of the assembly line. The development studio. It is a process

Games We Wish Never Were!



DAIKATANA: John Romero's favourite child turned out looking more like a nightmare kid for everyone else

TOMB RAIDER CHRONICLES: Even after Lara Croft's death, the sequels just won't stop



TRESPASSER: The digital sequel to *The Lost World*—a monstrosity that should have stayed lost